

be loaded on a web server, and can then be accessed with a web browser from any PC.

2.7 Open Source for design professionals

2.7.1 Modelling / Drawing Tools

freeCAD (<http://www.ar-cad.com/>)

This open source application is available for Linux, Windows and Mac. freeCAD is a “3d CAD with Motion Simulation” tool. Under Linux, installing freeCAD was easily accomplished.

Being a novice with design applications, the reviewer did find the menu options esoteric. But, to get things started, freeCAD has an extensive help system – every menu has an “Explain” option which describes the use of the menu.

Open source enthusiasts working in CAD and CAE environments should try out CAELinux at <http://www.caeLinux.com/CMS/>

Additionally a few sample drawings are included to set the ball rolling. The interface is minimalist, to the point of being drab. But, it has the controls and features that would be appreciated by design pros. freeCAD is adware, and the ad messages are continually refreshed which can be distracting at times.

Interesting options

Blender (www.blender.org) is a popular 3D design tool, available for Linux, Windows. And, if their screenshot galleries are taken as a yardstick, opencascade (www.opencascade.org) and BRL-CAD (brlcad.org) have impressive capabilities

Sweet Home 3D (<http://www.sweethome3d.eu>)

This is probably the only open source application of its kind aimed at interior designing. The application is available for Linux and Windows, and requires JRE 5 (JRE 1.5) to run. The reviewer learnt the hard way that the application has a preference for some graphics cards. On the reviewer’s system using ProSavage onboard graphics and DirectX 9c the app would exit with an error. From the screenshots available on the site, the application seems capable of rendering home interiors quite admirably. It has built in models for furniture, building structures such as staircase and pillars. The application can also